

Attack-Answer Companion

Twenty Common Attacks on the ARA Platform — With Answers and Discipline Notes

April 2026 · Read in full before using · Use with the Timed Pitches document

How to use this document

This is a preparation document, not a script. Read it in full before your first interview, debate, or door-knock. Know the answers well enough that you never sound like you're reciting them. The answers here are starting points — adapt the language to your voice and your district.

Each answer has a discipline note where one is needed. The discipline note is as important as the answer — it tells you what not to say, what frame to refuse, and where the trap is. An answer without discipline is just a longer way to lose.

Use with the Timed Pitches document. The pitches establish the positive case. This document handles what comes after. Together they cover most of what you'll face.

Quick Reference — 20 Attacks by Category

#	Category	Attack
1	Feasibility	"You'll never get this through Congress."
2	Feasibility	"This is too ambitious. You can't do all of this."
3	Feasibility	"We can't afford this."
4	Feasibility	"This will raise my taxes."
5	Feasibility	"Government can't run anything efficiently."
6	Ideology	"This is socialism."
7	Ideology	"You're too far left / this is too progressive."
8	Ideology	"You want to defund the military / you're weak on defense."
9	Credibility	"This was written by AI — it's not a real platform."
10	Credibility	"Who are you to present a governing platform? What's your track record?"
11	Credibility	"The scoring is made up. Who decides what gets a high score?"
12	Credibility	"Most of these things have never been tried."
13	Credibility	"Why should I trust a plan from one person with no institutional backing?"
14	Party / Coalition	"You're dividing the Democratic Party."
15	Party / Coalition	"The Democratic establishment will never let this happen."
16	Party / Coalition	"This will hand the seat to Republicans."
17	Electability	"You're not electable. You have no name recognition, no money, no party support."
18	Electability	"Project 2025 is already executing. It's too late."
19	Platform	"What makes you different from every other reform candidate?"
20	Platform	"You're promising things that past Democrats promised and never delivered."

Feasibility

Attacks on whether the platform can actually be implemented.

Attack 1**“You’ll never get this through Congress.”****Answer:**

Half our agenda doesn’t go through Congress. On Day 1, the President can direct the DOJ, the EPA, the Department of Labor, and the State Department to begin implementing 31 of our 65 proposals without a single Senate vote. The diplomatic relationships, the public health infrastructure, the Pentagon audit, the farm labor protections — none of that requires 60 votes. It requires a President who actually wants to do it. The legislation goes through Congress in sequence, starting with the proposals that have the broadest bipartisan support and building from there.

Discipline note:

Don’t enumerate all 31 executive actions. The power is in the frame: half our agenda, no congressional vote required. The list lives in the sequencing document. The public answer is the frame.

Attack 2**“This is too ambitious. You can’t do all of this.”****Answer:**

We’re not trying to do all of it at once. The platform has three phases over 30 years. Phase I is the five-year foundation — cost-of-living relief, anti-corruption, and infrastructure investment. Specific, achievable, broadly popular. We prove those work, then we expand. That’s not ambition. That’s sequencing. Every proposal is scored and phased. Nothing is promised before the conditions for it exist.

Attack 3**“We can’t afford this.”****Answer:**

We can’t afford what we have now. Americans spend twice what any comparable country spends on healthcare and get worse outcomes. We spend forty billion dollars a year on childcare that mostly doesn’t work. The IRS estimates six hundred billion dollars in taxes owed every year that aren’t collected because enforcement was defunded. The platform pays for itself in parts — the IRS reform, the antitrust enforcement, the waste reduction — before we spend a dollar of new money. The question isn’t whether we can afford a plan. It’s whether we can afford to keep going without one.

Discipline note:

Lead with the status quo cost, not the plan cost. The offense is stronger than the defense here.

Attack 4**“This will raise my taxes.”****Answer:**

It depends who you are. If you’re working for a living — wages, salary, hourly — your taxes don’t go up. The new revenue in this platform comes from three places: closing the offshore tax loopholes that wealthy individuals use to move money out of reach, taxing billionaire portfolio gains on an annual accrual basis the same way wages are taxed, and a digital services levy on the largest technology platforms. If none of those describe you, you’re not paying more. You’re getting lower childcare costs, pre-filled tax returns, and cheaper healthcare options instead.

Attack 5**“Government can’t run anything efficiently.”****Answer:**

Medicare runs at roughly 2% administrative overhead. Private insurance runs at 12 to 30 percent. The interstate highway system was built by the government. The internet was built by the government. The GPS in your phone was built by the government. The argument isn’t whether government can do things well — the historical record is clear that it can. The argument is whether this government, right now, has been resourced and held accountable to do its job. It hasn’t. That’s what we’re fixing.

Discipline note:

Don’t get defensive. The examples are strong — use them confidently. This attack is weakest when challenged with specifics.

Ideology

Attacks on the political character of the platform.

Attack 6**“This is socialism.”****Answer:**

The specific proposals in this platform exist and function in Germany, Canada, Australia, Japan, Denmark, and the United Kingdom — none of which are socialist countries. What we’re proposing is a public option for healthcare alongside private insurance, not nationalization. Antitrust enforcement of the kind Teddy Roosevelt used. Pre-filed tax returns that twenty-seven other countries already do. A childcare cost cap. These aren’t radical ideas — they’re mainstream policy in every comparable democracy. If that’s socialism, someone needs to explain what capitalism looks like in the rest of the developed world.

Discipline note:

Never accept the frame. Name the countries. The international precedent is the strongest argument — it’s why the scoring methodology exists.

Attack 7**“You’re too far left / this is too progressive.”****Answer:**

The proposals polling highest in this platform cross party lines. Seventy-six percent of Americans support banning congressional stock trading — including most Republicans. Broad majorities support pre-filed tax returns, childcare cost relief, and domestic manufacturing investment. If those positions are ‘too far left,’ then most of the country is too far left. What’s actually happening is that the political conversation in Washington has drifted so far from what ordinary people want that common sense looks radical by comparison.

Discipline note:

Cite the poll numbers when you have them. Make the opponent defend the status quo, not you defend the platform.

Attack 8**“You want to defund the military / you’re weak on defense.”****Answer:**

We spend more on defense than the next ten countries combined, and we still have a military that can’t pass an audit. Seven consecutive failed audits. Billions in contractor fraud that nobody is held accountable for. The platform calls for a Pentagon budget audit, a reduction in contractor dependence, and a pivot of some of that capacity toward domestic infrastructure — building the grid, the bridges, the supply chains that are themselves national security assets. A country whose semiconductor supply chain depends on adversaries isn’t secure, regardless of how large its defense budget is.

Discipline note:

Frame always as national security broadly defined, never as a cut. The audit argument is the strongest opener — it’s bipartisan and factually airtight.

Credibility

Attacks on the platform’s sources, methodology, and authorship.

Attack 9**“This was written by AI — it’s not a real platform.”****Answer:**

The ideas in this platform are human. The research, the policy judgments, the scoring decisions, the strategic choices about what to include and what to leave out — those are human. AI was used as a research and drafting tool, the same way a lawyer uses legal research software or a journalist uses a database. The full build history is publicly available — every decision, every change, every discussion. That level of transparency is something no institutional think tank can offer, because their process involves donor relationships and political negotiation they can’t show. Show me the methodology. Look at the sources. Engage with the argument.

Discipline note:

Lead with the transparency argument. The full provenance is public — that’s the strongest possible response to this attack. Don’t be defensive about the AI; be confident about the process.

Attack 10**“Who are you to present a governing platform? What’s your track record?”****Answer:**

The track record is the plan. Every proposal is scored, sourced, and publicly available. The legislative language is drafted. The phasing is documented. The constitutional risk is acknowledged where it exists. You don’t have to trust me — you can read it. The politicians who have the track record Washington recognizes have had thirty years to fix what’s broken. The track record I’m offering is a specific plan, not a résumé.

Discipline note:

This is the citizen candidacy argument. Don’t get drawn into biography. Redirect to the plan every time.

Attack 11**“The scoring is made up. Who decides what gets a high score?”****Answer:**

The scoring methodology is public and documented. Three axes: Global Precedent — has this worked in comparable countries? US Transition — how hard is it from current American political reality? Societal Benefit — what does the research say about population-wide welfare outcomes? Every score is derived from that framework, applied consistently across all proposals including the ones in this platform and the competing agendas. The same methodology that scores our proposals scores Project 2025 and the DNC 2024 platform. Anyone can apply it and check the work. If you think a score is wrong, make the argument — the methodology is open.

Discipline note:

The three-axis system is the strongest credibility argument in the platform. Know it cold.

Attack 12**“Most of these things have never been tried.”****Answer:**

They’ve been tried everywhere except here. The childcare cost cap exists in Denmark, Sweden, and France. Pre-filed taxes operate in twenty-seven countries. Medicare negotiating drug prices is how every other high-income country controls pharmaceutical costs. The public option exists in Canada, the UK, Germany, and Australia. The sourced edition of the framework documents the international precedent for every proposal — it’s specifically designed to document this. The question isn’t whether these things work — we know they work. The question is whether we’re willing to learn from what works.

Discipline note:

Have two or three specific country examples ready for the proposals most likely to be challenged. Germany and Japan are the strongest for bipartisan audiences — neither is seen as politically extreme.

Attack 13**“Why should I trust a plan from one person with no institutional backing?”****Answer:**

Because one person with no institutional backing is the only kind of person who can produce a plan like this without the plan being shaped by donor priorities. The Heritage Foundation spent twenty-two million dollars producing Project 2025. Every dollar of that money came with interests attached. This platform has no donors. No institutional backing. Nothing to protect except the argument. That’s not a weakness — that’s the only way to produce something that isn’t already compromised before it reaches you.

Party / Coalition

Attacks on the relationship between the ARA and the Democratic Party.

Attack 14**“You’re dividing the Democratic Party.”****Answer:**

The division already exists — between the party’s voters and the interests that have been running it. Donor-class Democrats who benefit from the status quo, revolving-door figures whose career paths depend on it, corporate relationships that have shaped Democratic policy for decades — those interests are not the party’s voters. They’re a small, powerful layer that sits between the coalition and its own governing power. Naming that isn’t creating a split. It’s describing one that was already there. The question is whether we pretend it doesn’t exist or build something that actually serves the people the party claims to represent.

Discipline note:

Never accept ‘dividing the party’ as the frame. The counter-frame is: ‘We are not running against the Democratic Party. We are running against the interests that have been running it.’

Attack 15**“The Democratic establishment will never let this happen.”****Answer:**

The Democratic establishment doesn’t decide what gets legislated. Voters do. Candidates do. The establishment’s power is in controlling the pipeline — endorsements, funding, organizational support. What this platform does is create a path that doesn’t depend on that pipeline. Any citizen can run on it without permission. Any voter can demand it without asking. The establishment’s influence over any specific candidate is real. Its influence over an idea that’s already public is zero.

Attack 16**“This will hand the seat to Republicans.”****Answer:**

Running on nothing has been handing seats to Republicans for a generation. The theory that Democrats need to minimize their platform to be electable has been tested repeatedly and the evidence doesn’t support it. The proposals with the highest polling in this platform are bipartisan by any measure. The argument that specificity is a liability assumes voters prefer vagueness — but voters in competitive districts are not looking for less. They’re looking for someone who sounds like they actually have a plan. That’s what this is.

Discipline note:

This attack is strongest in primaries. The response is strongest when grounded in local polling data. Where possible, know the numbers for your specific district.

Electability

Attacks on the candidate’s viability.

Attack 17

“You’re not electable. You have no name recognition, no money, no party support.”

Answer:

Name recognition is built by having something worth recognizing. Money follows credibility, and credibility comes from having a specific, defensible plan that people can hold you accountable to. Party support follows electoral performance, and electoral performance follows from making an argument that resonates with people whose lives are actually affected by the policies. The conventional path — name recognition first, then a platform — is the path that produces the candidates we have. This is the other path. It starts with the plan.

Discipline note:

This is the citizen candidacy argument. Don’t defend the lack of institutional support — make it the point.

Attack 18

“Project 2025 is already executing. It’s too late.”

Answer:

It’s not too late to make the case, and making the case is how it eventually becomes not too late to win. The history of political reform in this country is not a history of immediate victories — it’s a history of ideas that were dismissed as impossible right up until they weren’t. The ARA exists now. The legislative language is drafted. The platform is public. Every candidate who runs on it and loses makes the ideas more visible and the constituency for them more legible. The window is not closed. It is harder to walk through than it was two years ago. That is not the same thing.

Platform

Attacks on the platform’s distinctiveness and deliverability.

Attack 19

“What makes you different from every other reform candidate?”

Answer:

The specificity. Most reform candidates have a direction. This platform has sixty-five specific proposals, twelve drafted bills, a three-phase implementation sequence, and an honest account of what can be done without Congress and what requires legislation. ‘I believe in change’ is a direction. The American Renewal Agenda is a governing plan. You can read it, check every position against the public document, and hold me accountable if I diverge from it. That accountability mechanism doesn’t exist when the platform is a mood.

Discipline note:

Lead with the specificity argument every time this comes up. The plan’s transparency is the differentiator — use it.

Attack 20

“You’re promising things that past Democrats promised and never delivered.”

Answer:

The failure of past Democratic platforms was usually one of two things: the promise was made without a sequenced plan for delivery, or it depended entirely on legislative wins that were never guaranteed. This platform is designed around both problems. The executive action layer — thirty-one proposals that require no congressional vote — means visible delivery starts on Day 1, regardless of what Congress does. The legislative sequence starts with the proposals that have the broadest bipartisan support and builds from demonstrated success. And the plan is public. If I don’t deliver on Phase I, you can read exactly what Phase I promised and hold me to it. That’s a different kind of accountability than a campaign speech.

Discipline note:

Acknowledge the history honestly — it earns trust. Then distinguish on mechanism, not intention. Voters have heard about intentions.

PUB_ARI_ · American Renewal Initiative · Attack-Answer Companion · April 2026 Use with: Timed Pitches, Candidate Orientation, Ideological Toolkit. The full platform and methodology are publicly available.